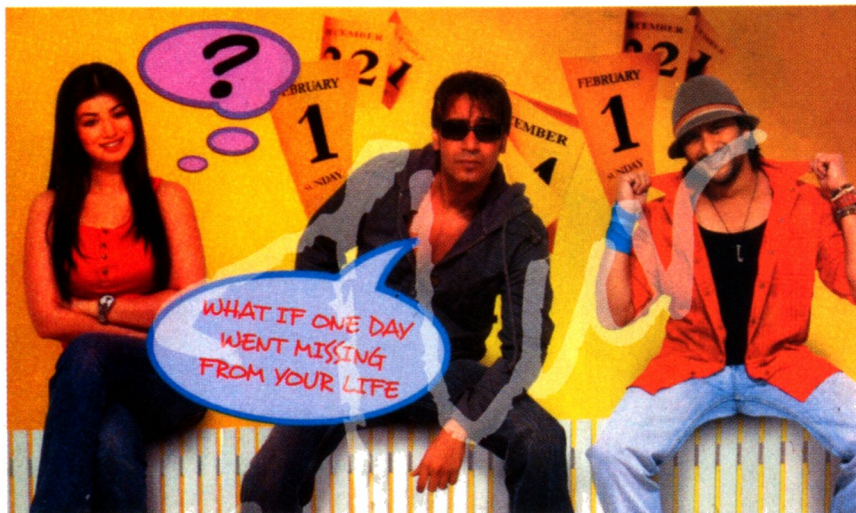




SUNDAY made with a budget of Rs 20 cr went missing at the box-office

their minds and making blunders," says independent producer Sunil Manchanda, CEO, Mad Films, that sold *Salaam-e-Ishq* to Eros.

Somewhere in between this buying and selling, it's the audience that's suffering the losses. In a country where movie watching is the primary means of entertainment, the viewers feel cheated week after week when they see films that don't live up to their expectations. "The problem is that instead of viewing it as a film, people are seeing it as a project from which money can be made through various revenue streams," says Siddharth Roy Kapoor, CEO, UTV Films. The other reason, as some producers point out, is the lack of unity in this supposedly closed-knit industry. "Everyone is out to kill the other film. So release dates clash all the time and it doesn't look like it will stop soon," says a production head. So while *Krazzy 4* was released along with *U, Me Aur Hum*, the latest target is Harman Baweja's *Love Story 2050* that at least two producers are going after.

It's a dramatic time for the Hindi film industry, not only in terms of the crores on the balance sheets but also because the audiences, especially in multiplexes, have turned critics. They no longer declare a film good or bad. Today, they have an opinion. While Kapoor says the main focus should be on the script, Singh says, "It's becoming increasingly important to go after the consumer and give him what he wants. And we need to stop believing that one film will work for everybody.

If *Sarkar Raj* is an intense film, it won't work for children so it shouldn't be sold as a family drama." After all, when at the end of the week, a distributor releases his figures, every producer likes to see his film as a hit. He may have already made his profits by selling the satellite, music, distribution, DVD and ringtone rights, but even with these revenue streams, nothing boosts confidence as a hit does. And for the audience, it's Rs 150 well spent. ■

If you make bhelpuri, sell it as bhelpuri. If you sell it as pasta, you can't expect them to accept it." A spate of films gone wrong is possibly the reason why YRF is being quite careful about the way it projects its next film, Kunal Kohli's *Thoda Pyar Thoda Magic*.

While YRF rethinks its strategies, there are others who're not even thinking of approaching the story board. For these production houses making their presence felt, albeit by releasing mediocre films, is more important. Pyramid Saimira, a company that has been producing, marketing and distributing films in the south, made its entry into Hindi films with the Rajkumar Santoshi-directed Rs 20-crore *Halla Bol*. The film was a social commentary but people weren't impressed. And though critics spared the film, its two other disastrous releases, *Sirf* and *Jimmy*, were booed by the critics and the audience alike.

This is the strategy that another production house, Eros, seems to be following too. Though it reaped huge profits on *Om Shanti Om* last year, it seems to be presenting nothing but below average reel time this year. It has already released eight films this year, from the Rs 20-crore *Sunday* to the Rs 15-crore *One Two Three* that have flopped. "Corporates are entering with just money on

SOME DISAPPOINTMENTS AT THE BOX-OFFICE

Film	Budget (approx)	All India Net (approx)
Sarkar Raj*	Rs 35 cr	Rs 25 cr
You, Me Aur Hum	Rs 25 cr	Rs 24 cr
Tashan	Rs 40 cr	Rs 27 cr
Halla Bol	Rs 20 cr	Rs 9 cr
Krazzy 4	Rs 18 cr	Rs 19 cr
One Two Three	Rs 18 cr	Rs 15 cr
Bombay to Bangkok	Rs 4 cr	Rs 2 cr

All-India net source: www.ibosnetwork.com

* Still in theatres

ONE TWO THREE numbers were as dismal as its script

